How much is the wind worth? Wind effects on sprint and horizontal-jump performance across age and ability in a national competition registry

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Abstract

Every empirical estimate of how wind affects track-and-field performance comes from elite seniors, yet wind rules — the ±2.0 m/s legality threshold above all — apply identically to ten-year-olds and world-class sprinters. Using the Norwegian Athletics Federation's competition registry, which records gauge readings down to the youth 60 m, we estimated wind effects within athlete × season across five sprint and four horizontal-jump events at ages 10–34: 401 240 analysed results, of which 300 989, lying in 76 048 athlete-season-event cells with at least two wind-measured marks, identify the estimates, with month and round controls and standard errors clustered on meet. Per m/s of wind (a linear fit over head- and tailwinds), results changed by 0.059 s on 60 m, 0.082 s on 100 m, 0.121 s on 200 m, 3.1 cm in the long jump and 4.2 cm in the triple jump. On the tailwind side alone a metre per second was worth 0.047, 0.065 and 0.078 s in the three sprints, about 1.1–1.6 times the published elite estimates for the 100 m, which our senior stratum approaches as the endpoint of a gradient. The absolute sprint effect declined with age (200 m, males: 0.144 s per m/s at 10–11 to 0.085 at 20–34) and with ability within age, scaling approximately with race duration: per second of race time the effect was 0.0059–0.0063 s per m/s in the straight sprints against 0.0040–0.0043 in the bend events. Headwinds cost more than tailwinds gave in sprints (100 m: 0.107 vs. 0.065 s per m/s, $p < 0.001$) — on the 100 m by about as much as drag physics predicts for the observed winds, on the 60 m by less and on the 200 m by more. In a post-plan extension, class-specific 60 m hurdles matched the flat 60 m, while the 100 and 110 m hurdles mostly exceeded the flat 100 m (by up to 48 %), partly because they take longer to run. Valued over 0 to +2 m/s, the +2.0 m/s window was worth 0.15–0.16 s on the 100 m at 12–13 against 0.11–0.15 s among seniors — most in seconds where athletes are slowest, but most relative to their own within-season variability among seniors. Uniform wind rules thus permit the largest absolute wind contribution exactly where raw marks are most used to rank and select, and the registry already contains the age-specific corrections estimated here.

Keywords: wind; sprint; long jump; youth athletics; measurement; age-group competition; registry study

1 Introduction

Wind is the one weather variable athletics regulates. Sprint and horizontal-jump results count for records only when tailwind does not exceed 2.0 m/s, gauge readings are part of the official result, and seasonal lists in many countries separate legal from wind-aided marks. How much the wind actually moves a result has been estimated in two ways: physical and quasi-physical models of the sprint (Linthorne, 1994; Mureika, 2001), and data-driven analyses of elite competition results (Moinat et al., 2018; Hollings et al., 2012). Both traditions agree on the order of magnitude for elite seniors — roughly 0.04–0.06 s per m/s in the 100 m, somewhat more for women than for men — and both concern elite seniors only. Reviews of sprint testing likewise treat wind as a condition to standardise, with correction factors derived from adult data (Haugen and Buchheit, 2016).

Yet nothing guarantees that elite estimates transfer down the age and ability range, and the physics pulls in two directions. A slower runner spends longer on the course — a 12-year-old needs roughly a third more time over 100 m than a senior — so any given wind acts on them longer, inflating the absolute time effect. But aerodynamic drag scales with the square of airspeed, so slower runners spend a smaller share of their power against air, deflating it; children's higher surface-to-mass ratio pushes the other way again. The net scaling of the wind effect across age and ability is an empirical question that elite data cannot answer, and it matters practically: age-group records, seasonal youth lists, age-graded scoring tables and qualification standards all treat marks within ± 2.0 m/s as equivalent, in every age class, and talent evaluation leans on exactly these marks (Guttormsen, 2026).

The Norwegian registry is unusually well placed to answer it. Every sanctioned result in Norway is registered, and wind is measured and recorded down to the outdoor 60 m sprints that children contest from age 10 — to our knowledge the only population-scale source of wind-measured sprint data on children. We pre-specified five questions: the direction of the effect within athlete and season (H1, a design check); how the absolute effect scales with age (H2 — the exposure-time and aerodynamic-share mechanisms predict opposite directions); how the percentage effect scales (H3); whether headwinds cost more than tailwinds give (H4, as aerodynamics predicts); and what the ± 2.0 m/s window is worth in each class, expressed against

athletes' own performance variability (H5). The analysis plan was committed to version control before estimation; the study was not externally preregistered. At the author's initiative after the main estimations, class-specific short hurdles were added as a documented extension.

2 Methods

2.1 Data

We used a frozen extract (29 October 2026) of the Norwegian Athletics Federation's results database, which holds results electronically from 2011 (with thinner coverage in 2011, the first electronic season). The main analysis covers all results from 2011 onwards in nine wind-measured events: 60 m, 80 m, 100 m, 150 m and 200 m sprints, and long jump, long jump from a take-off zone, triple jump and triple jump from a zone (in the zone variants, used in the youngest classes, take-off is from a marked zone rather than a board, which reduces fouls). The hurdles extension covers the ten short-hurdle event codes with substantive wind data (60 m to 110 m hurdles; each code specifies the class's hurdle height, so a code identifies an age-class specification). Only approved, outdoor, electronically timed results of athletes with known sex and birth year were analysed, at calendar-year ages 10–34, with event-specific plausibility bounds and wind readings within ± 8 m/s. Before these filters we removed two kinds of duplicate record: 47 962 board-jump rows that re-imports in 2026 had copied from an identical take-off-zone result (same athlete, date, mark and wind; almost all at ages 11–13, and listed in the source only under the zone event), and 771 exact duplicates, mostly meets stored twice. Of 670 803 extracted rows in the main events, 401 240 entered the analysis. The largest exclusions were indoor results — principally the indoor 60 m (86 449 rows), 200 m (35 849) and long jump (27 556) — and 16 369 outdoor rows without a wind value (overall, 4.7 % of approved outdoor results lack a reading). Missing wind is a completeness rather than a selection concern: it is concentrated in the smallest meets (8.9 % of rows in the smallest third of meets by size, against 1.4 % in the largest third) and its yearly share fluctuates between 2 and 6 %. Of the analysed rows, 300 989 lie in athlete-season-event cells with at least two wind-measured results and identify the estimates; the hurdles extension contributed 33 205 analysed rows. Times are

analysed in seconds and jumps in metres (reported in centimetres); units were verified against known magnitudes per event.

2.2 Statistical model

The identifying variation is within athlete × season × event: the same athlete, in the same event and season, racing under different winds. For each event we estimated

$$y_{it} = \alpha_{i(\text{athlete}\times\text{year})} + \beta \cdot \text{wind}_{it} + \text{month dummies} + \text{round dummies} + \varepsilon_{it},$$

by within-demeaning; 76 048 athlete-season-event cells contribute at least two wind-measured results, and estimates are reported only where at least 300 results in 100 athlete-seasons contribute. Because the gauge reading is constant within a race, the race — and conservatively the meet — is the natural clustering level (Moulton, 1986); standard errors are therefore clustered on meet, counting the absorbed athlete-season effects in the small-sample correction because they are not nested within meets, with athlete clustering (the analysis plan's original choice, which gives intervals roughly half as wide in the large sprints and somewhat narrower ones elsewhere) retained as robustness. The month dummies are pooled across years and capture a common within-season profile; year-specific shocks are absorbed only in the meet fixed-effects specification. β is reported per m/s of wind, signed as a gain with tailwind, in seconds or centimetres, and in percent from a log-outcome specification; because headwinds cost more than tailwinds give, this linear slope averages the two sides, and statements about tailwinds use the separate tailwind slope. Age-band (10–11 through 20–34) and sex-specific models address H2/H3; ability tertiles address ability scaling, with ability defined as the athlete-season mean of *wind-adjusted* performance (each mark corrected to still air with the event-level slope), so that the ability measure itself is not contaminated by wind exposure, and the contributing athlete-seasons divided into equal thirds within event × sex × age band; separate slopes for head- and tailwind address H4; a quadratic term probes curvature. For H5, the advantage of a +2.0 m/s tailwind over still air is twice the slope over 0 to +2 m/s, estimated for each event, sex and age band in a piecewise model with separate slopes for headwinds and for tailwinds above +2

(the response flattens above +2, so a single tailwind slope would understate the window, and the symmetric slope would overstate it). It is expressed in seconds and as a share of a robust within-athlete-season scale: 1.4826 times the median absolute deviation of within-cell residuals of wind-adjusted marks, over cells with at least three results and corrected for the estimated cell means. The robust scale is needed because the event-wide plausibility bounds admit a few gross recording errors (for example 200 m times filed as 100 m), which barely move the slopes but inflate a classical standard deviation. Pre-specified robustness analyses required at least three results per cell, excluded readings of exactly 0.0, split the period (2011–2019 vs. 2021–2026; 2020, whose season was curtailed by the pandemic, belongs to neither half), and replaced month dummies with meet fixed effects (two-way demeaning); a post-plan check excluded readings within ± 0.2 of +2.0. Analyses used Python 3.13.7 with pandas 2.3.3, numpy 2.4.1 and statsmodels 0.14.6.

Two interpretive rules were fixed in advance. First, a single gauge reading does not measure the wind each athlete met; to the extent this error is classical it attenuates estimates toward zero, so the sprint effects are read as lower bounds. The measurement protocol also differs by event family: under World Athletics rules the gauge beside the straight averages 10 s from the gun in the 100 m (13 s in the short hurdles), 10 s from when the leader enters the straight in the 200 m — so it measures the wind over only part of a course that is half bend — and 5 s per attempt in the jumps; Norwegian practice applies the same conventions to the domestic distances (60 and 80 m as the 100 m; 150 m as the 200 m). Comparisons across event families bear this in mind. Second, wind is not randomly assigned: identification relies on within-season comparisons with month, round and (in robustness) meet controls, and no causal language beyond this design sense is used. For the jumps, one further caveat applies: the registry stores only the wind of the measured (best) attempt, which describes the conditions of a series imperfectly, and the direction of the resulting bias is not established; the lower-bound reading is therefore applied to the sprints only.

2.3 Ethics and transparency

The data are competition results registered by the Norwegian Athletics Federation: results from age 13 are publicly listed, while records for the 10–12 age classes are registered but not publicly released by the federation. No athlete is identified. Performance data below age 13 are used solely to estimate measurement conditions — not to rank, list or evaluate children — in keeping with the purpose of the Norwegian children's sport regulations; no result of an athlete under 13 appears in ranked, listed or identifiable form in the paper or its outputs. The project falls outside the Norwegian Health Research Act; an assessment from Sikt was obtained. The analysis plan was committed to version control before estimation; code and aggregate estimation files are available from the author, and athlete-level files are regenerable from the registry. Reporting follows STROBE where applicable (von Elm et al., 2007).

3 Results

3.1 Sample and wind exposure

Table 1 describes the nine main events. Wind readings centred near calm with wide spread (median +0.3 m/s; 5th–95th percentile -2.1 to +2.7). The distribution shows digit preference — 8.8 % of readings are exactly 0.0, more than any continuous wind distribution would place there and consistent with some unoperated gauges being recorded as calm, and 16 % fall on whole metres per second — and thins just above the legality line: 3.4 % of readings lie in (1.8, 2.0] against 2.2 % in (2.0, 2.2], with 1.6 % exactly +2.0. Both patterns motivate robustness checks: excluding exact zeros, and excluding readings within ± 0.2 of +2.0, leave every estimate essentially unchanged (Table S2). The bulk of the material is young: the 60 m, contested outdoors by the youngest classes, is the largest single event (103 286 analysed results, of which 72 558 lie in athlete-seasons with at least two wind-measured races and thus contribute to estimation).

Table 1: Analysed events: volume, marks, and wind exposure (2011–2026).

Event	Results	In cells ≥2	Athlete-seasons	Athletes	Median mark	Wind, median (p5–p95)
60 m	103 286	72 558	19 354	10 790	9.59 s	+0.1 (−2.3–+2.5)
80 m	5 795	1 410	620	466	12.53 s	+0.0 (−2.6–+2.5)
100 m	76 430	64 557	13 222	5 451	12.88 s	+0.4 (−2.2–+2.8)
150 m	2 151	328	150	125	19.64 s	+0.3 (−2.5–+2.2)
200 m	76 113	59 246	15 549	6 608	27.99 s	+0.4 (−2.2–+2.9)
Long jump	58 179	40 060	9 533	4 982	4.35 m	+0.5 (−1.6–+2.7)
Long jump (zone)	54 665	44 336	12 338	7 835	3.64 m	+0.3 (−1.7–+2.7)
Triple jump	16 761	13 068	3 421	1 800	10.09 m	+0.7 (−1.3–+2.9)
Triple jump (zone)	7 860	5 426	1 861	1 413	8.42 m	+0.4 (−1.5–+2.8)

Results: analysed rows (approved, outdoor, electronic, ages 10–34, wind within ±8 m/s). In cells ≥2: the estimation sample (the n of Table 2). Athlete-seasons and athletes: units contributing to estimation in that event. Counts and wind summaries are computed from the analysis file; the estimation files are available from the author.

3.2 What a metre per second is worth (H1)

Table 2 reports the main within-athlete estimates. Per m/s of wind, results changed by 0.059 s (95 % CI 0.057–0.061) on 60 m, 0.082 s (0.080–0.085) on 100 m, 0.121 s (0.113–0.130) on 200 m, 3.1 cm (2.9–3.4) in the long jump and 4.2 cm (3.5–4.8) in the triple jump; in percentage terms, 0.40–0.69 % per m/s. All directions matched H1. The small 80 m and 150 m events gave consistent estimates with wide intervals.

Table 2: Effect per m/s of wind (linear fit over head- and tailwinds, signed as a gain with tailwind), within athlete × season (95 % CIs clustered on meet).

Event	Per m/s, linear (95 % CI)	Percent per m/s (95 % CI)	n	Athlete-seasons
60 m	0.059 s (0.057–0.061)	0.626 (0.602–0.649)	72 558	19 354
80 m	0.075 s (0.062–0.088)	0.630 (0.531–0.729)	1 410	620
100 m	0.082 s (0.080–0.085)	0.646 (0.625–0.666)	64 557	13 222
150 m	0.081 s (0.045–0.118)	0.467 (0.278–0.656)	328	150
200 m	0.121 s (0.113–0.130)	0.442 (0.410–0.474)	59 246	15 549
Long jump	3.15 cm (2.87–3.43)	0.685 (0.619–0.751)	40 060	9 533
Long jump (zone)	2.11 cm (1.90–2.32)	0.570 (0.513–0.628)	44 336	12 338
Triple jump	4.16 cm (3.54–4.79)	0.396 (0.335–0.458)	13 068	3 421
Triple jump (zone)	3.88 cm (2.87–4.89)	0.449 (0.331–0.568)	5 426	1 861

Point estimates are identical under athlete clustering (the analysis plan's original choice), whose intervals are roughly half as wide in the large sprints and somewhat narrower elsewhere; both sets are in the estimation files available from the author.

The published elite figures of roughly 0.04–0.06 s per m/s on the 100 m (Linthorne, 1994; Moinat et al., 2018) mainly describe tailwinds. On the tailwind side alone, the population slopes were 0.047 s (60 m), 0.065 s (100 m) and 0.078 s (200 m) per m/s (Table 4), so the 100 m figure is about 1.1–1.6 times the elite range. Restricted to seniors (20–34), the 100 m tailwind slope was 0.064 s for men and 0.057 s for women, at or just above the elite range — and our senior men, averaging about 11.4 s on the 100 m, are themselves slower than the elite samples. The elite literature describes the fast end of a gradient.

3.3 The effect falls with age — and with speed (H2, H3)

Figure 1 and Table 3 show the core result. In absolute seconds, the wind effect declined with age in every sprint and both sexes — monotonically in every series except the sparse girls' 200 m at 10–11: on 200 m for boys and men from 0.144 s per m/s at 10–11 to 0.085 at 20–34; on 60 m from 0.070 at 10–11 to 0.041 at 16–17; on 100 m from 0.101 at 12–13 to 0.071 at 20–34. The exposure-time mechanism wins: mean race durations shrink in almost the same proportion

(men's 100 m, 14.97 s at 12–13 vs. 11.42 s at 20–34, a ratio of 1.31, against a wind-effect ratio of 1.42), so the percentage effect (Figure 2) is far flatter — but not constant, declining for instance from 0.70 to 0.62 % per m/s on the men's 100 m and from 0.70 to 0.52 % on the 60 m. Dividing each event's effect by its mean race duration makes the scaling explicit (Table S4): the straight sprints line up at 0.0059–0.0063 s per m/s per second of race time, while the bend events sit a third lower (150 m 0.0040, 200 m 0.0043) — as expected when the gauge, read beside the home straight, measures the wind over only part of a course that is half bend, and when the wind meets the runner at varying angles through the bend. In the jumps the absolute effect for girls and women ran the other way, rising with age in centimetres (long jump: 2.6 cm per m/s at 12–13 to 4.1 at 20–34) as jump distances and flight times grow, but not for boys and men (3.5 at 12–13, 3.1 at 20–34), and the percentage effect shows no consistent age direction (Table S1). Within age bands, ability scaling follows the sprint pattern (Figure 3): with ability measured as the wind-adjusted season mean, the lowest tertile gained most per m/s in every sprint (100 m: 0.088 s against 0.079 in the highest tertile; 60 m: 0.066 against 0.056; 200 m: 0.133 against 0.117), while the jump tertiles did not separate. Slower athletes — whether young or simply weaker — are exposed longer, and no single correction factor, absolute or proportional, is exactly age-invariant.

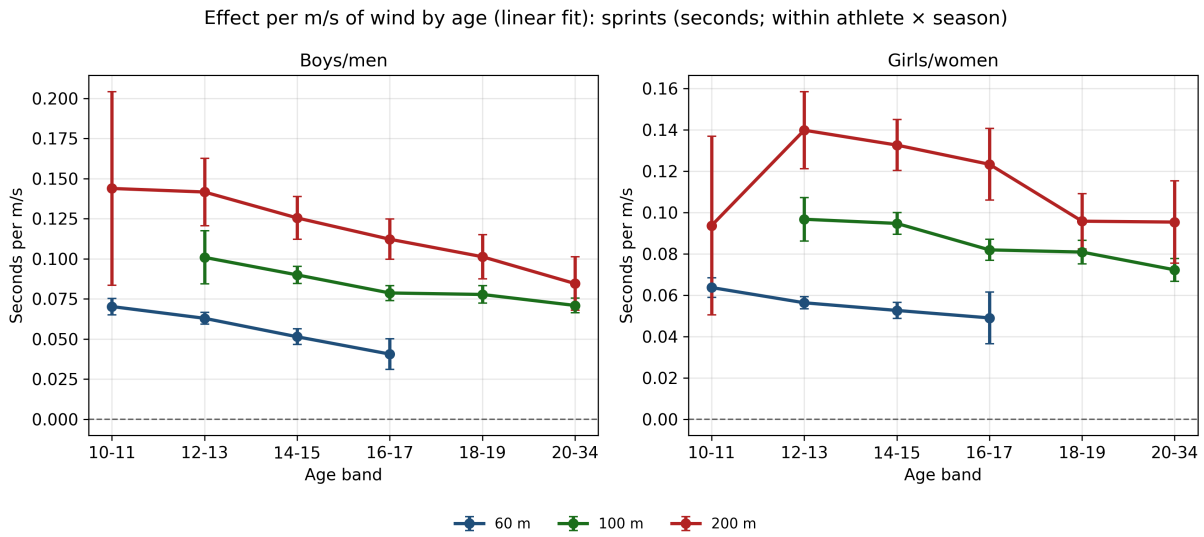


Figure 1: Effect per m/s of wind (linear fit over head- and tailwinds) by age band, in seconds, for sprints (within athlete × season; 95 % CIs clustered on meet).

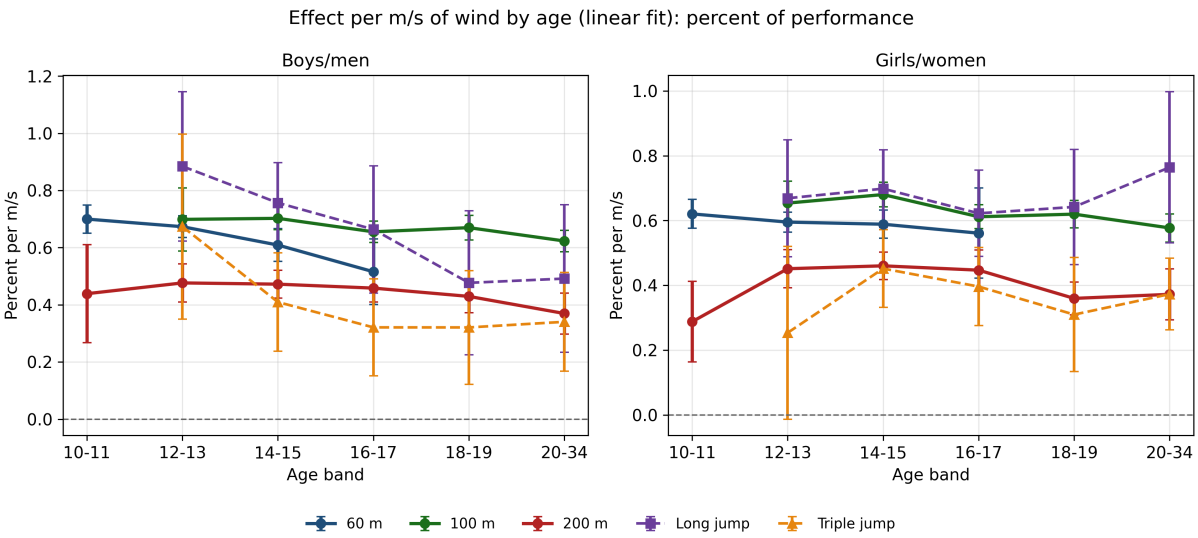


Figure 2: The same scaling in percent of performance, for sprints (solid lines) and horizontal jumps (dashed). For the sprints the percentage effect is far flatter across age than the absolute effect, but still declines; the jumps show no consistent age direction (95 % CIs clustered on meet).

Table 3: Effect per m/s of wind (linear fit; seconds, 95 % CI clustered on meet) by age band and sex, sprints.

Event	Sex	10–11	12–13	14–15	16–17	18–19	20–34
60 m	Boys/men	0.070 (0.065–0.075)	0.063 (0.059–0.067)	0.051 (0.046–0.056)	0.041 (0.031–0.050)	—	—
60 m	Girls/women	0.064 (0.059–0.068)	0.056 (0.053–0.059)	0.053 (0.049–0.057)	0.049 (0.037–0.061)	—	—
100 m	Boys/men	—	0.101 (0.084–0.117)	0.090 (0.085–0.095)	0.079 (0.074–0.083)	0.078 (0.072–0.083)	0.071 (0.066–0.075)
100 m	Girls/women	—	0.097 (0.086–0.107)	0.095 (0.089–0.100)	0.082 (0.077–0.087)	0.081 (0.075–0.087)	0.072 (0.067–0.078)
200 m	Boys/men	0.144 (0.083–0.204)	0.142 (0.121–0.163)	0.125 (0.112–0.139)	0.112 (0.100–0.125)	0.101 (0.088–0.115)	0.085 (0.068–0.101)
200 m	Girls/women	0.094 (0.050–0.137)	0.140 (0.121–0.159)	0.133 (0.120–0.145)	0.123 (0.106–0.141)	0.096 (0.082–0.109)	0.095 (0.075–0.115)

Dashes: fewer than 300 results in 100 athlete-seasons, the reporting threshold (60 m above 17, which is rarely run outdoors; 100 m at 10–11, where 60 m is the standard sprint). Table values are reproduced from the estimation files available from the author.

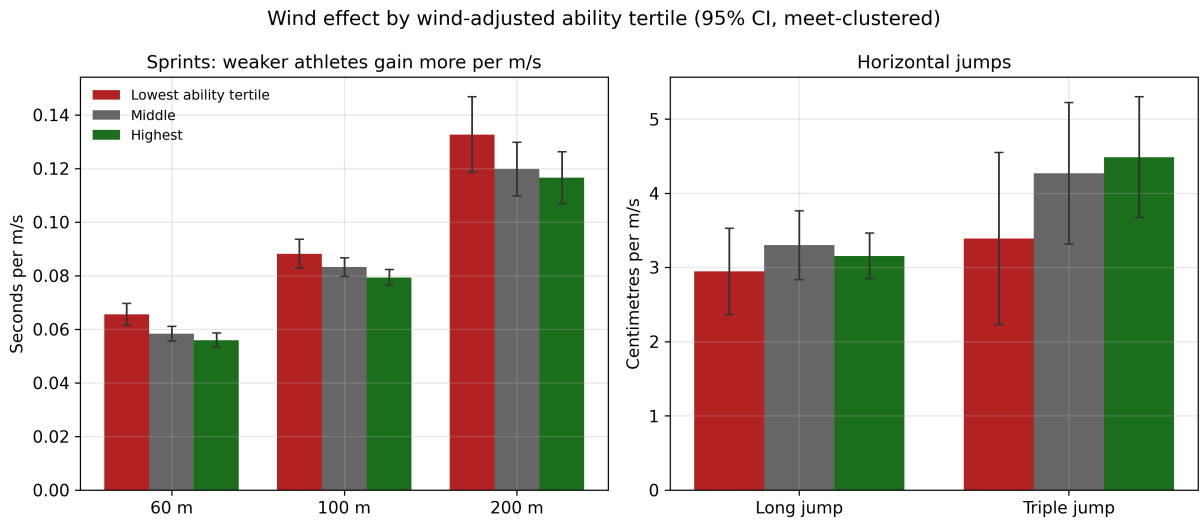


Figure 3: Wind effect by ability tertile: athlete-seasons divided into equal thirds of the wind-adjusted season mean within event × sex × age band (95 % CIs clustered on meet).

3.4 Headwinds cost more than tailwinds give (H4)

In every large sprint event the headwind slope exceeded the tailwind slope (Figure 4; Table 4): on 100 m a -1 m/s headwind cost 0.107 s against a +1 m/s tailwind's 0.065 s ($p < 0.001$ for equal slopes); on 200 m, 0.184 against 0.078; on 60 m, 0.072 against 0.047. The positive quadratic terms tell the same story (200 m: +0.0141 s per $(\text{m/s})^2$, SE 0.0013; Table S5). Drag proportional to the square of airspeed predicts this direction, and on the straight sprints also roughly this size. The familiar ratio $(2v+1)/(2v-1) \approx 1.14$–$1.18$ describes a wind of exactly ± 1 m/s, not slopes averaged over the observed range of winds; imposing drag-only physics (time change proportional to the change in squared airspeed at the athlete's mean speed) on the observed winds and fitting the same piecewise model predicts head/tail ratios of 1.84 (60 m), 1.72 (100 m) and 1.85 (200 m), against observed 1.52, 1.66 and 2.36, and quadratic terms of 0.0048, 0.0063 and 0.0099 against observed 0.0037, 0.0057 and 0.0141. The 100 m thus matches drag closely, the 60 m is somewhat less asymmetric, and only the 200 m — where the gauge reads only the home straight — is more asymmetric than drag alone predicts. In the jumps the two slopes did not differ significantly in the long jump (2.98 against 3.54 cm, p = 0.29), and in the zone variants the tailwind slope was the steeper one; since the registry stores only the wind of the measured attempt, the jump asymmetries are not interpreted.

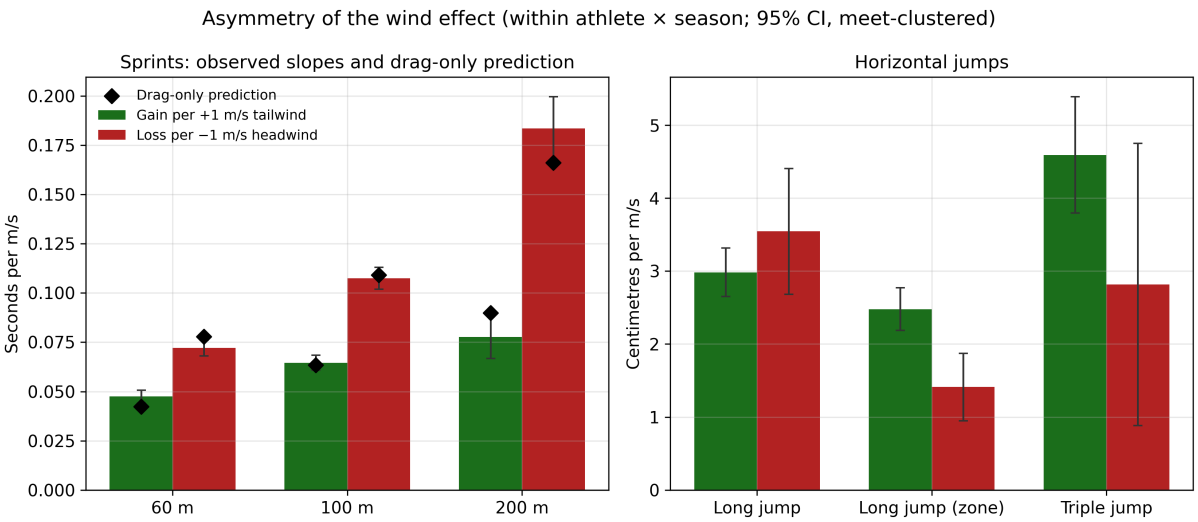


Figure 4: Separate head- and tailwind slopes (within athlete × season; 95 % CIs clustered on meet). Black diamonds: the slopes that drag-only physics predicts for the observed winds (sprints).

Table 4: Asymmetry: separate tail- and headwind slopes, observed head/tail ratio, and the ratio drag-only physics predicts for the same estimator (95 % CIs clustered on meet).

Event	Unit	Tailwind gain per +1 m/s	Headwind loss per −1 m/s	Ratio	Drag-only ratio	p equal slopes
60 m	s	0.047 (0.044–0.051)	0.072 (0.068–0.076)	1.52	1.84	<0.001
80 m	s	0.072 (0.048–0.097)	0.078 (0.054–0.101)	1.07	1.72	0.805
100 m	s	0.065 (0.061–0.068)	0.107 (0.102–0.113)	1.66	1.72	<0.001
150 m	s	0.093 (0.031–0.154)	0.067 (−0.031–0.164)	0.72	1.80	0.721
200 m	s	0.078 (0.067–0.089)	0.184 (0.168–0.199)	2.36	1.85	<0.001
Long jump	cm	2.98 (2.65–3.32)	3.54 (2.68–4.41)	1.19	—	0.291
Long jump (zone)	cm	2.48 (2.19–2.77)	1.41 (0.95–1.87)	0.57	—	<0.001
Triple jump	cm	4.59 (3.80–5.39)	2.82 (0.88–4.75)	0.61	—	0.133
Triple jump (zone)	cm	4.69 (3.40–5.98)	1.90 (−0.25–4.04)	0.40	—	0.044

Drag-only ratio: time changes proportional to the change in squared airspeed at the athlete's mean speed, imposed on the observed winds and estimated with the same piecewise model. The simpler ratio $(2v+1)/(2v-1)$ for a wind of exactly ± 1 m/s is 1.14–1.18. No benchmark is given for the jumps, where wind acts on run-up and flight differently.

3.5 Short hurdles: like flat sprints over 60 m, larger over 100 and 110 m

In the age-class system, hurdle events carry class-specific heights, so each event code identifies an age-class specification. Across the ten codes with wind data (Table 5; Figure 5), the 60 m hurdles matched the flat 60 m of the same sex and class: 0.055–0.067 s per m/s against 0.056–0.070, point estimates from 21 % below to 9 % above the flat references, with overlapping intervals. Over 100 and 110 m the hurdle estimates mostly exceeded the flat 100 m reference, from 4 % below to 48 % above; in the girls' 76.2 cm class (0.108 against 0.082) the hurdle interval lies entirely above the flat interval, and in the boys' 84 cm class (0.133 against 0.090) it lies above the flat point estimate but overlaps the flat interval. Per second of race time the pooled hurdle codes (0.0048–0.0069 s per m/s) span the straight-sprint rates (Table S4), so the hurdles' longer race times account for much of the difference, though not all of it in those two youth classes. The age gradient reappeared within a distance: on the 100 m hurdles, 0.108 s per m/s for girls' 76.2 cm at 16–17 and 0.133 for boys' 84 cm at 14–15, against 0.069 for the senior women's 84 cm event.

Table 5: Wind effect in short hurdles by class-specific event code (sex-specific rows; flat-sprint reference for the same sex and distance class in that sex's modal age band for the code; 95 % CIs clustered on meet).

Event (hurdle height)	Sex	Modal band	Gain per +1 m/s (95 % CI), s	Flat reference (95 % CI), s	n
60 m hurdles 68 cm	Boys	10–11	0.055 (0.033–0.077)	0.070 (0.065–0.075)	1 214
60 m hurdles 68 cm	Girls	10–11	0.067 (0.048–0.086)	0.064 (0.059–0.068)	2 562
60 m hurdles 76.2 cm	Boys	12–13	0.063 (0.048–0.078)	0.063 (0.059–0.067)	3 435
60 m hurdles 76.2 cm	Girls	12–13	0.062 (0.051–0.073)	0.056 (0.053–0.059)	7 222
80 m hurdles 76.2 cm	Girls	14–15	0.072 (0.051–0.092)	—	2 520
80 m hurdles 84 cm	Boys	14–15	0.078 (0.051–0.104)	—	1 473
100 m hurdles 76.2 cm	Girls	16–17	0.108 (0.089–0.128)	0.082 (0.077–0.087)	1 046
100 m hurdles 84 cm	Boys	14–15	0.133 (0.092–0.174)	0.090 (0.085–0.095)	709
100 m hurdles 84 cm	Women	20–34	0.069 (0.041–0.097)	0.072 (0.067–0.078)	2 842
100 m hurdles 91.4 cm	Boys	16–17	0.084 (0.052–0.115)	0.079 (0.074–0.083)	679
110 m hurdles 91.4 cm	Boys	16–17	0.103 (0.035–0.171)	0.079 (0.074–0.083)	583
110 m hurdles 100 cm	Men	18–19	0.096 (0.036–0.155)	0.078 (0.072–0.083)	656
110 m hurdles 106.7 cm	Men	20–34	0.084 (0.047–0.121)	0.071 (0.066–0.075)	588

The hurdles analysis was added after the main estimations at the author's initiative and is documented as a post-plan extension. Flat references are the 60 m or 100 m estimate for the same sex in that sex's modal age band; the flat 80 m has too few results at 14–15 for a reference. Codes with fewer than 300 results for one sex have only the other sex's row.

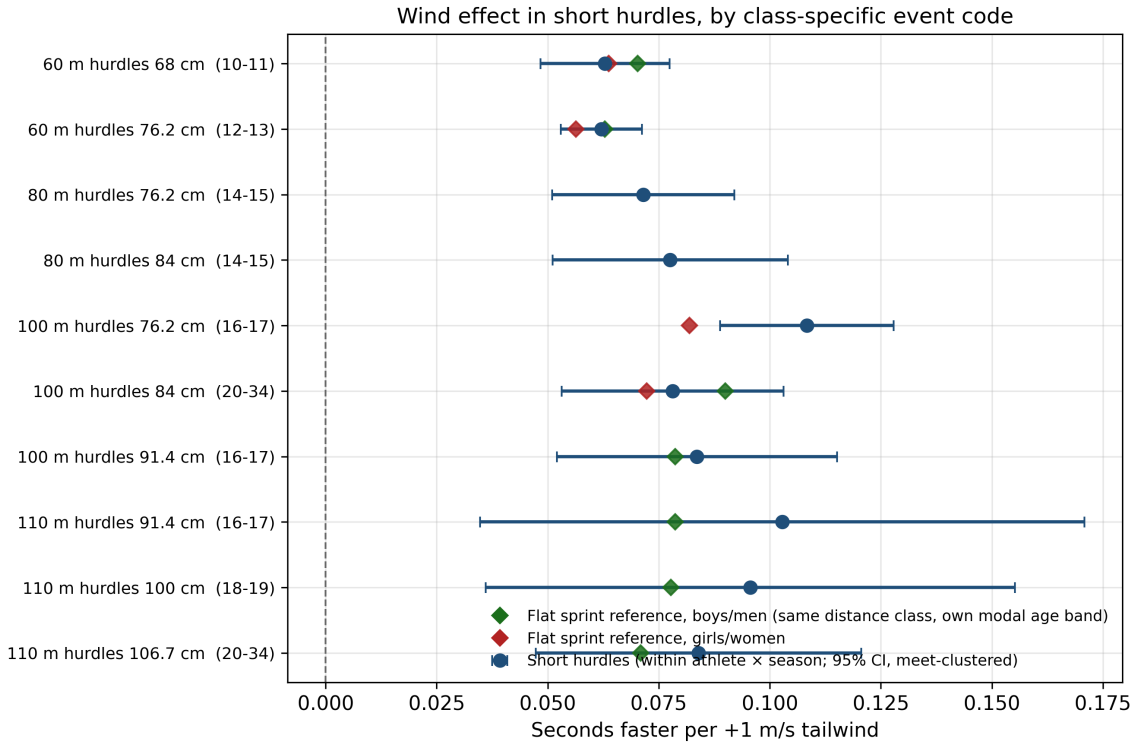


Figure 5: Short hurdles: wind effect per class-specific code (pooled sexes; dots with 95 % CIs clustered on meet) against flat-sprint references for each sex (diamonds; boys/men green, girls/women red).

3.6 What the legal window is worth in each class (H5)

Table 6 translates the estimates into the quantity the rules regulate: the advantage of a +2.0 m/s tailwind over still air, valued from the slope over 0 to +2 m/s (Section 2.2) and expressed in seconds and as a share of a robust measure of the athlete's own within-season variability. In seconds, the window is worth most where athletes are slowest: 0.16 s on the boys' 100 m at 12–13 and 0.15 s for girls, against 0.15 and 0.11 s among seniors; 0.25 s on the girls' 200 m at 12–13 against 0.14 s for senior women. Relative to the athlete's own variability the pattern reverses: the window is worth 0.29–1.26 of the robust scale across events, sexes and ages, and most among senior sprinters, whose marks scatter least (men's 100 m: 0.67 at 12–13 against 1.26 at 20–34). Two external yardsticks complete the picture. On the federation's age-graded scoring tables, +2.0 m/s on the 100 m converts to 22–29 points at age 13 against 17–25 points on the oldest (age-19) table, because the senior tables are steeper per second. And in the 2025

national 100 m season lists, correcting tailwind-aided marks to still air with the class-specific slopes brings two new athletes into the top 10 of the girls' class-14 list and of the senior men's list (none in the boys' class-14 list), and in the senior men's list 86 % of top-50 marks carried tailwinds above +1 m/s: wind moves rankings at youth and senior ages alike, most where lists are decided by hundredths.

Table 6: Advantage of a +2.0 m/s tailwind over still air, valued from the slope over 0 to +2 m/s: seconds, and in parentheses the share of the athlete's robust within-season scale of wind-adjusted performance.

Event	Sex	10–11	12–13	14–15	16–17	18–19	20–34
60 m	Boys/men	0.11 s (0.64)	0.13 s (0.90)	0.11 s (0.96)	0.09 s (0.99)	—	—
60 m	Girls/women	0.11 s (0.66)	0.11 s (0.83)	0.09 s (0.76)	0.06 s (0.59)	—	—
100 m	Boys/men	—	0.16 s (0.67)	0.15 s (0.91)	0.14 s (1.03)	0.16 s (1.25)	0.15 s (1.26)
100 m	Girls/women	—	0.15 s (0.68)	0.15 s (0.82)	0.13 s (0.86)	0.14 s (1.04)	0.11 s (0.90)
200 m	Boys/men	0.27 s (0.37)	0.16 s (0.29)	0.16 s (0.41)	0.19 s (0.66)	0.13 s (0.47)	0.14 s (0.53)
200 m	Girls/women	0.51 s (0.62)	0.25 s (0.45)	0.20 s (0.47)	0.18 s (0.51)	0.16 s (0.50)	0.14 s (0.52)

Seconds are 2× the slope over 0 to +2 m/s from a piecewise model with separate slopes for headwinds and for tailwinds above +2 (Table S3 gives the slopes). The robust scale is 1.4826 × the median absolute deviation of within-cell residuals of wind-adjusted marks over cells with at least three results, per event × sex × band — a denominator free of the wind-driven variance itself, of singleton-cell bias and of gross recording errors. Values reproduced from the estimation files available from the author. The 60 m rows at 16–17 and the 200 m rows at 10–11 rest on thin samples.

3.7 Robustness

Estimates were essentially unchanged when cells required three or more results, when exact-zero readings were excluded, when readings within ±0.2 of +2.0 were excluded, across period halves, and under athlete instead of meet clustering (Table S2; point estimates are identical under either clustering). Replacing month dummies with meet fixed effects — which compares results only within the same meet and absorbs any meet-level weather or gauge siting — attenuated the 60, 100 and 200 m estimates by 13–41 % (100 m: 0.082 to 0.066 s per m/s), left the small 80 and 150 m events essentially unchanged, and raised the jump estimates by 26–49 %. Only 25–34 % of the sprint wind variance lies within meets (40–52 % in the jumps, where at-

tempts spread across the day), so the meet-FE estimates rest on far less variation. The sprint attenuation is compatible with gauge error that weighs more once between-meet variation is removed, but also with some between-meet confounding in the month-dummy estimates; these data cannot separate the two, and the rise in the jumps shows that meet-level factors can push either way. The age gradient survived meet fixed effects: in every sprint series the estimate fell from the youngest well-measured band to 20–34 (men's 100 m: 0.107 s per m/s at 12–13 to 0.060 at 20–34; Table S6).

4 Discussion

4.1 Principal findings

In the first population-scale estimates of wind effects across age and ability, a metre per second of wind (linear fit over head- and tailwinds) was worth 42–70 % more, in absolute terms, to a boy sprinter than to a senior man — 0.10 versus 0.07 s on 100 m at 12–13, 0.14 versus 0.08 s on 200 m at 10–11 — and 34–47 % more among girls aged 12–13, with the published elite values (Linthorne, 1994; Mureika, 2001; Moinat et al., 2018; Hollings et al., 2012) emerging as the fast endpoint of a continuous gradient. On the tailwind side alone the boys' 100 m contrast was small (0.071 versus 0.064 s, overlapping intervals) and the girls' larger (0.083 versus 0.057 s). The gradient's dominant mechanism is exposure time: effects scaled approximately with race duration, across age and equally across ability within age, and the percentage effect was accordingly much flatter — though still mildly declining. The residual decline cannot be the aerodynamic share, which grows with speed and would push the percentage effect the other way; it is consistent with a fixed wind being a larger fraction of a slower runner's airspeed, and perhaps with children's higher surface-to-mass ratio. Headwinds cost sprinters more than tailwinds gave them, by about as much as drag physics predicts for the observed winds on the 100 m, by less on the 60 m, and by more on the 200 m, where the gauge covers only the straight; in a post-plan extension, class-specific short hurdles matched flat sprints over 60 m and exceeded them over 100 and 110 m, partly through longer race times.

4.2 Implications

For measurement, the results supply what has been missing: empirically grounded, age- and event-specific wind values for youth athletics, with a full correction table by event, sex and age band in Table S3. Since neither the absolute nor the percentage effect is strictly invariant, corrections should be age-graded; a single senior-derived factor understates youth wind effects by up to two-fifths. For fairness, the ± 2.0 m/s legality window is not age-neutral in the units lists are kept in: it licenses the largest contribution in seconds, and the largest share of race time, in the youngest and slowest classes. Relative to athletes' own within-season variability the window is worth less for the young than for seniors (on the 100 m, 0.67–0.68 of the robust scale at 12–13 against 0.90–1.26 at 20–34), and on the age-graded scoring tables similar points — so the inequity is specific to raw-seconds comparisons, which is exactly what season lists, records and qualifying standards are. The 2025 list exercise makes it concrete: still-air correction changes who is in the top 10, senior lists included. The practical conclusions are modest and do not require rule changes: report and store wind with youth results (as Norway does), prefer wind-adjusted or wind-stratified comparisons when marks inform selection or records, and treat single wind-assisted breakthroughs with proportionate scepticism. For talent evaluation the point compounds a broader lesson of the identification literature — early performance is an unreliable selection signal (Vaeyens et al., 2008; Guttormsen, 2026): at the ages where selection decisions lean hardest on raw times, those times carry the most weather per second of racing.

4.3 Strengths and limitations

Strengths include scale (401 240 analysed results, 300 989 of them identifying; 76 048 athlete-season-event cells), a within-athlete design that removes stable athlete and seasonal composition, direction-and-magnitude agreement with the elite literature at the senior endpoint, internal consistency across age, ability, events and the hurdles extension, and a plan committed before estimation. Limitations are stated as read rules: gauge readings mismeasure athlete-experienced wind, so to the extent the error is classical the sprint estimates are lower bounds, and the meet-FE attenuation shows how much identification leans on between-meet wind variation; the gauge

protocol differs by event family, and for the bend events measures only part of the course, so cross-family comparisons (and the low per-second rates of the 150/200 m) partly reflect measurement rather than physiology; wind is not randomised, and within-season form-weather covariation is controlled only by month, round and meet terms; jump estimates use the wind of the measured attempt only, so their bias direction is not established; the event-wide plausibility bounds admit a few gross recording errors, which barely move the slopes but motivated the robust scale in H5; the senior stratum is 20–34, so masters athletics is outside scope; missing wind (4.7 % of approved outdoor results, concentrated in the smallest meets) limits completeness but gives no mechanism for bias within athlete-seasons; temperature and other weather are unobserved (a meteorological linkage is a natural extension); and the setting is one federation's registry, though the mechanisms are physical and should travel.

5 Conclusion

Wind effects in athletics are not a constant to be borrowed from elite studies. Per m/s of wind they are 34–70 % larger for child sprinters than for seniors because slower athletes are exposed longer, they fall with ability for the same reason, and headwinds cost more than tailwinds give, by about as much as drag physics predicts on the straight sprints. The ± 2.0 m/s window was calibrated on the athletes for whom a metre per second costs the fewest seconds, and it licenses the largest raw-seconds wind contribution in the classes that race slowest. The remedy requires no new rules, because it operates on lists rather than races: wind is already recorded with every result, and the age-specific corrections estimated here (Table S3) can make lists, records and talent evaluation measurably fairer — for seniors too — while every race is run exactly as before.

Declarations

Funding. The author received no funding for this work.

Competing interests. The author declares no competing interests. The author maintains an open, non-commercial statistics platform built on the federation's public results database.

Ethics. Competition results registered by the Norwegian Athletics Federation (publicly listed from age 13; registered but not publicly released for the 10–12 age classes); no individual is identified; performance data below age 13 are used only to estimate measurement conditions, never to rank or evaluate children. Outside the scope of the Norwegian Health Research Act; Sikt assessment obtained.

Data availability. The underlying data are the Norwegian Athletics Federation's competition results; records for the 10–12 age classes are not publicly released and cannot be shared at the individual level. Analysis code and aggregate estimation files are available from the author; athlete-level files are regenerable from the registry.

Author contributions. AGG conceived the study, performed all analyses, and wrote the manuscript.

Declaration of AI use. The author used a large language model (Claude, Anthropic) for programming assistance and manuscript drafting support. The author reviewed, verified, and edited all content and takes full responsibility for the integrity of the work.

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Supplementary material

Table S1: Wind effect in the horizontal jumps by age band (gain per +1 m/s; values girls/women / boys/men; 95 % CIs clustered on meet).

Event	Unit	10–11	12–13	14–15	16–17	18–19	20–34
Long jump	cm	—	2.63 (1.94–3.32) / 3.46 (2.46–4.46)	2.89 (2.42–3.35) / 3.36 (2.82–3.89)	3.04 (2.48–3.60) / 3.71 (2.68–4.74)	3.20 (2.40–3.99) / 2.94 (1.58–4.29)	4.15 (3.03–5.27) / 3.11 (1.69–4.52)
Long jump	%	—	0.67 (0.49–0.85) / 0.88 (0.62–1.15)	0.70 (0.58–0.82) / 0.76 (0.62–0.90)	0.62 (0.49–0.76) / 0.66 (0.44–0.89)	0.64 (0.46–0.82) / 0.48 (0.23–0.73)	0.76 (0.53–1.00) / 0.49 (0.23–0.75)
Long jump (zone)	cm	1.83 (1.41–2.24) / 2.39 (1.88–2.90)	1.86 (1.59–2.14) / 2.54 (2.17–2.91)	—	—	—	—
Long jump (zone)	%	0.55 (0.42–0.68) / 0.70 (0.54–0.85)	0.49 (0.41–0.56) / 0.66 (0.56–0.75)	—	—	—	—
Triple jump	cm	—	2.36 (0.08–4.65) / 6.58 (3.63–9.53)	4.18 (3.07–5.29) / 4.20 (2.49–5.91)	4.13 (2.88–5.37) / 4.10 (2.09–6.11)	3.52 (1.68–5.36) / 4.21 (1.67–6.76)	4.43 (3.14–5.72) / 4.89 (2.55–7.23)
Triple jump	%	—	0.25 (−0.01–0.52) / 0.67 (0.35–1.00)	0.45 (0.33–0.57) / 0.41 (0.24–0.58)	0.40 (0.28–0.52) / 0.32 (0.15–0.49)	0.31 (0.13–0.49) / 0.32 (0.12–0.52)	0.37 (0.26–0.48) / 0.34 (0.17–0.51)

In each cell the first value is girls/women, the second boys/men. The zone events are contested only in the youngest classes. In centimetres the effect rises with age for girls and women as jump distances and flight times grow; in percent it shows no consistent age direction.

Table S2: Robustness: gain per +1 m/s under alternative specifications (point estimates; s for sprints, cm for jumps).

Event	Primary	Cells $\geq$3	No exact 0.0	Excl. $\pm$0.2 of +2.0	2011–19	2021–26	Meet FE
60 m	0.0591	0.0590	0.0591	0.0587	0.0600	0.0573	0.0513
80 m	0.0746	0.0711	0.0761	0.0743	0.0740	0.0779	0.0768
100 m	0.0823	0.0816	0.0823	0.0828	0.0843	0.0795	0.0659
150 m	0.0814	—	0.0780	0.0865	—	—	0.0838
200 m	0.1215	0.1203	0.1215	0.1207	0.1258	0.1135	0.0713
Long jump	3.1498	3.1064	3.2449	3.2355	3.2396	3.0276	4.0094
Long jump (zone)	2.1133	2.0471	2.1538	2.1406	2.1337	2.1518	2.6624
Triple jump	4.1647	4.1451	4.2652	4.2381	3.8149	5.0653	6.2220
Triple jump (zone)	3.8821	3.3154	3.8589	3.7672	3.7075	4.8247	5.0930

Point estimates are identical under athlete and meet clustering; only intervals differ. The 150 m lacks the cells-$\geq$3 and period columns for want of data.

Table S3: Correction table: tailwind slope over 0 to +2 m/s, and separate tail- and headwind slopes, by event, sex and age band (sprints; jumps event-level, in cm), with 95 % CIs clustered on meet.

Event	Sex	Age band	Tailwind 0 to +2	Tailwind slope per +1 m/s (95 % CI)	Headwind slope per −1 m/s (95 % CI)	n
60 m	Boys/men	10–11	0.057	0.055 (0.046–0.064)	0.088 (0.077–0.098)	7 635
60 m	Boys/men	12–13	0.066	0.056 (0.050–0.062)	0.071 (0.064–0.078)	15 457
60 m	Boys/men	14–15	0.054	0.042 (0.036–0.049)	0.062 (0.051–0.073)	6 955
60 m	Boys/men	16–17	0.046	0.019 (0.004–0.035)	0.064 (0.049–0.080)	570
60 m	Girls/women	10–11	0.055	0.044 (0.036–0.052)	0.085 (0.076–0.094)	9 794
60 m	Girls/women	12–13	0.057	0.047 (0.042–0.051)	0.067 (0.062–0.072)	21 886
60 m	Girls/women	14–15	0.046	0.038 (0.032–0.043)	0.068 (0.062–0.075)	9 320
60 m	Girls/women	16–17	0.030	0.021 (0.007–0.034)	0.091 (0.068–0.113)	389
100 m	Boys/men	12–13	0.082	0.071 (0.041–0.102)	0.141 (0.111–0.170)	1 755
100 m	Boys/men	14–15	0.073	0.072 (0.063–0.081)	0.113 (0.102–0.123)	7 499
100 m	Boys/men	16–17	0.069	0.062 (0.054–0.070)	0.102 (0.094–0.111)	9 879
100 m	Boys/men	18–19	0.079	0.067 (0.058–0.077)	0.093 (0.080–0.107)	6 030
100 m	Boys/men	20–34	0.073	0.064 (0.058–0.071)	0.082 (0.071–0.092)	8 909
100 m	Girls/women	12–13	0.073	0.083 (0.062–0.105)	0.112 (0.091–0.134)	2 733
100 m	Girls/women	14–15	0.073	0.071 (0.063–0.079)	0.126 (0.116–0.135)	9 740
100 m	Girls/women	16–17	0.066	0.059 (0.052–0.066)	0.112 (0.102–0.122)	9 062
100 m	Girls/women	18–19	0.072	0.064 (0.057–0.072)	0.106 (0.092–0.120)	4 207
100 m	Girls/women	20–34	0.055	0.057 (0.050–0.064)	0.098 (0.087–0.109)	4 543
200 m	Boys/men	10–11	0.133	0.107 (0.023–0.191)	0.194 (0.090–0.298)	1 301
200 m	Boys/men	12–13	0.081	0.076 (0.041–0.111)	0.217 (0.174–0.259)	5 443
200 m	Boys/men	14–15	0.079	0.078 (0.059–0.096)	0.188 (0.164–0.212)	7 147
200 m	Boys/men	16–17	0.094	0.074 (0.060–0.088)	0.172 (0.146–0.198)	6 372
200 m	Boys/men	18–19	0.063	0.069 (0.053–0.084)	0.149 (0.124–0.173)	4 158
200 m	Boys/men	20–34	0.070	0.048 (0.026–0.070)	0.151 (0.125–0.178)	4 931
200 m	Girls/women	10–11	0.256	0.099 (0.025–0.173)	0.086 (−0.012–0.185)	1 780
200 m	Girls/women	12–13	0.127	0.105 (0.080–0.130)	0.181 (0.143–0.219)	7 710
200 m	Girls/women	14–15	0.100	0.094 (0.075–0.113)	0.186 (0.162–0.211)	8 640
200 m	Girls/women	16–17	0.091	0.066 (0.049–0.082)	0.208 (0.173–0.243)	5 854
200 m	Girls/women	18–19	0.081	0.065 (0.047–0.082)	0.151 (0.120–0.183)	2 956
200 m	Girls/women	20–34	0.071	0.047 (0.025–0.070)	0.180 (0.143–0.218)	2 954
Long jump	Both	all	—	2.98 (2.65–3.32) cm	3.54 (2.68–4.41) cm	40 060
Long jump (zone)	Both	all	—	2.48 (2.19–2.77) cm	1.41 (0.95–1.87) cm	44 336
Triple jump	Both	all	—	4.59 (3.80–5.39) cm	2.82 (0.88–4.75) cm	13 068
Triple jump (zone)	Both	all	—	4.69 (3.40–5.98) cm	1.90 (−0.25–4.04) cm	5 426

Worked example: a girls' 12–13 100 m run in +1.8 m/s is corrected by $1.8 \times 0.073 = 0.13$ s to still air, using the slope over 0 to +2 m/s. Sprint slopes are in seconds; the four jump rows are in centimetres, pooled across bands. The 60 m rows at 16–17 rest on thin outdoor samples.

Table S4: Effect per second of race time: gain per +1 m/s divided by mean race duration, flat sprints and short hurdles.

Event	Mean time (s)	Gain per +1 m/s (s)	Per second of race time
60 m	9.67	0.059	0.00611
80 m	12.58	0.075	0.00594
100 m	13.09	0.082	0.00629
150 m	20.22	0.081	0.00403
200 m	28.47	0.121	0.00427
60 m hurdles 68 cm	13.16	0.063	0.00478
60 m hurdles 76.2 cm	11.82	0.062	0.00525
80 m hurdles 76.2 cm	13.36	0.072	0.00535
80 m hurdles 84 cm	14.09	0.078	0.00551
100 m hurdles 76.2 cm	15.61	0.108	0.00694
100 m hurdles 84 cm	14.94	0.078	0.00523
100 m hurdles 91.4 cm	15.66	0.084	0.00534
110 m hurdles 91.4 cm	15.90	0.103	0.00646
110 m hurdles 100 cm	15.74	0.096	0.00608
110 m hurdles 106.7 cm	15.53	0.084	0.00540

Straight flat sprints cluster at 0.0059–0.0063 per m/s per second of race time; the bend events (150/200 m) sit about a third lower; hurdle codes bracket the flat rates.

Table S5: Quadratic specification: linear and quadratic wind terms (raw outcome units per m/s: seconds for sprints, metres for jumps, e.g. 0.0322 m = 3.22 cm; SEs clustered on meet).

Event	Linear term (SE)	Quadratic term (SE)	n
60 m	−0.0596 (0.0010)	0.0037 (0.0004)	72 558
80 m	−0.0752 (0.0065)	0.0013 (0.0026)	1 410
100 m	−0.0856 (0.0014)	0.0057 (0.0005)	64 557
150 m	−0.0794 (0.0194)	−0.0052 (0.0109)	328
200 m	−0.1307 (0.0038)	0.0141 (0.0013)	59 246
Long jump	0.0322 (0.0021)	−0.0004 (0.0007)	40 060
Long jump (zone)	0.0194 (0.0012)	0.0015 (0.0004)	44 336
Triple jump	0.0377 (0.0045)	0.0020 (0.0015)	13 068
Triple jump (zone)	0.0342 (0.0060)	0.0030 (0.0018)	5 426

Negative linear terms for sprints mean faster times with tailwind. Positive quadratic terms in the large sprints match the headwind-tailwind asymmetry of Table 4.

Table S6: Meet fixed effects by age band: effect per m/s of wind with month dummies replaced by meet fixed effects (seconds, 95 % CI clustered on meet), sprints.

Event	Sex	10–11	12–13	14–15	16–17	18–19	20–34
60 m	Boys/men	0.055 (0.045–0.066)	0.055 (0.049–0.061)	0.047 (0.040–0.055)	0.030 (0.011–0.048)	—	—
60 m	Girls/women	0.056 (0.049–0.063)	0.049 (0.043–0.054)	0.047 (0.041–0.052)	0.030 (0.012–0.048)	—	—
100 m	Boys/men	—	0.107 (0.072–0.143)	0.071 (0.056–0.085)	0.063 (0.050–0.075)	0.060 (0.046–0.073)	0.060 (0.051–0.069)
100 m	Girls/women	—	0.093 (0.077–0.109)	0.077 (0.066–0.089)	0.065 (0.057–0.072)	0.069 (0.059–0.080)	0.062 (0.054–0.070)
200 m	Boys/men	−0.000 (−0.147–0.146)	0.091 (0.054–0.128)	0.078 (0.054–0.102)	0.063 (0.038–0.088)	0.058 (0.026–0.090)	0.053 (0.033–0.072)
200 m	Girls/women	0.030 (−0.082–0.142)	0.087 (0.060–0.113)	0.080 (0.061–0.100)	0.079 (0.057–0.100)	0.071 (0.047–0.094)	0.059 (0.006–0.111)

Same reporting threshold as Table 3. The 200 m at 10–11 has too few results per meet for the meet-FE estimate to be informative.